Lecture # 3

Understanding People at work (part 2)

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Positive and Negative Affectivity

- You may have noticed that ***behavior*** is also a function of ***moods***.



- When people are in a ***good mood***,
  - they may be more cooperative
  - smile more,
  - and act friendly



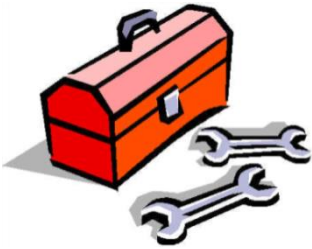
- When these same people are in a ***bad mood***,
  - they may have a tendency to be picky
  - Irritable
  - Less tolerant of different opinions

Positive and Negative Affectivity

- ***Positive affective*** people experience positive moods more frequently, whereas negative affective people experience negative moods with greater frequency.
- ***Negative affective*** people focus on the "***glass half empty***" and experience more anxiety and nervousness.
- When a team comprises mostly negative affective people, there tend to be fewer instances of ***helping*** and ***cooperation***.
- When people with a lot of power are also high in positive affectivity, the work environment is affected in a positive manner and can lead to greater levels of cooperation and finding mutually agreeable solutions to problems.

OB Toolbox: I work with a negative person

- **Understand that you are unlikely to change someone else's personality:**
  - Personality is relatively stable and criticizing someone's personality will not bring about change.
  - If the behavior is truly disruptive, focus on behavior, not personality.



- **Keep an open mind:**
  - Just because a person is constantly negative does not mean that they are not sometimes right.
  - Listen to the feedback they are giving you.

OB Toolbox: I work with a negative person

- **Set a time limit:** If you are dealing with someone who constantly ***complains*** about things, you may want to ***limit*** these conversations to prevent them from consuming your time at work.

- **You may also empower them to act on the negatives they mention:** The next time an overly negative individual complains about something, ask that person to think of ways to change the situation and get back to you.



- **Ask for specifics:** If someone has a negative tone in general, you may want to ask for specific examples for what the problem is.

Self-Monitoring

- Self-monitoring refers to the extent to which a ***person is capable*** of monitoring his/her actions and appearance in social situations.
- People who are social monitors are ***social chameleons*** who understand what the situation demands and ***act accordingly***, while low social monitors tend to act the way they feel.
- High social monitors are sensitive to the types of behaviors the social environment expects from them.
- Their greater ability to modify their behavior according to the demands of the situation and to manage their impressions effectively is a great advantage for them.

Self-Monitoring

- In general, they tend to be ***more successful*** in their careers.
- Second, high social monitors tend to experience higher levels of stress, probably caused by behaving in ways that conflict with their true feelings.
- In situations that demand positive emotions, they may act happy although they are not feeling happy, which puts an emotional burden on them.
- Finally, high social monitors tend to be less committed to their companies.

Proactive Personality

- **Proactive personality** refers to a person's inclination to fix what is perceived as wrong, ***change*** the ***status quo***, and use initiative to solve problems.
- Instead of waiting to be told what to do, proactive people ***take action*** to initiate meaningful change and remove the obstacles they face along the way.
- In general, having a proactive personality has a number of advantages for these people.
- **For example**, they tend to be more successful in their job searches.

Proactive Personality

- They are also more successful over the course of their careers, because they use initiative and acquire ***greater understanding*** of the ***politics within*** the organization.
- They ***adjust*** to their new jobs quickly because they understand the political environment better and often make friends more quickly.
- Proactive people are eager to learn and engage in many developmental activities to ***improve their skills***.
- Research shows that the success of proactive people depends on
  - their understanding of a company's core values
  - their ability and skills to perform their jobs
  - their ability to assess situational demands correctly

Self-Esteem

- ***Self-esteem*** is the degree to which a person has overall ***positive feelings*** about his or herself.
- People with high self-esteem view themselves in a positive light, are confident, and respect themselves.
- On the other hand, people with low self-esteem experience high levels of self-doubt and question their self-worth.
- High self-esteem is related to higher levels of satisfaction with one's job and higher levels of performance on the job.
- People with low self-esteem are attracted to situations in which they will be relatively invisible, such as large companies.

Self-Esteem

- Managing employees with low self-esteem may be challenging at times, because ***negative feedback*** given with the intention to improve performance may be viewed as a judgment on their worth as an employee.

- Therefore, effectively managing employees with relatively low self-esteem ***requires tact*** and providing lots of positive feedback when discussing performance incidents.

Self-Efficacy

- **Self-efficacy** is a belief that one can perform a ***specific task successfully***.
- Research shows that the belief that we can do something is a good predictor of whether we can actually do it.
- You may have high self-efficacy in being successful ***academically***, but low self-efficacy in relation to your ability to ***fix your car***.
- At the same time, people have a certain level of generalized self-efficacy and they have the belief that whatever task or hobby they tackle, they are likely to be successful in it.

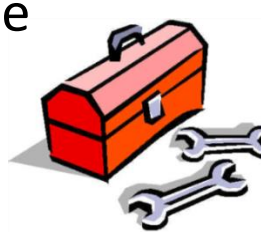
Self-Efficacy

Is there a way of increasing employees' self-efficacy?

- Hiring people who are capable of performing their tasks and training people to increase their self-efficacy may be effective.
- Some people may also respond well to verbal encouragement. By showing that you believe they can be successful and effectively playing the role of a cheerleader, you may be able to increase self-efficacy.
- Giving people opportunities to test their skills so that they can see what they are capable of doing (or ***empowering them***) is also a good way of increasing self-efficacy.

OB Toolbox: Ways to build your Self-Confidence

- **Take a self-inventory:** What are the areas in which you lack confidence? Then consciously tackle these areas.
  - Take part in training programs; seek opportunities to practice these skills. Confront your fears head-on.



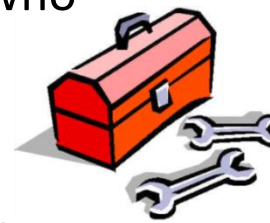
- **Set manageable goals:** Success in challenging goals will breed self-confidence, but do not make your goals impossible to reach.
  - If a task seems daunting, break it apart and set mini goals.

- **Find a mentor**. A mentor can point out areas in need of improvement, provide accurate feedback, and point to ways of improving yourself.

OB Toolbox: Ways to build your Self-Confidence

- **Don't judge yourself by your failures:** Everyone fails, and the most successful people have more failures in life. Instead of assessing your self-worth by your failures, learn from mistakes and move on.

- **Until you can feel confident, be sure to act confident**: Acting confident will influence how others treat you, which will boost your confidence level.
  - Pay attention to how you talk and behave, and act like someone who has high confidence.



- **Know when to ignore negative advice**. If you receive negative feedback from someone who is usually negative, try to ignore it. Surrounding yourself with naysayers is not good for your self-esteem.

Perception

Perception

- Our behavior is not only a function of our personality, values, and preferences, but also of the situation. We interpret our environment, formulate responses, and act accordingly.

- ***Perception*** (from Latin word perceptio) is the organization, identification, and ***interpretation*** of sensory information in order to represent and understand the environment.

- All perception ***involves signals*** in the nervous system, which in turn result from physical or chemical stimulation of the sense organs.

Perception

Perception can be split into two processes

- ***Firstly,*** processing sensory input, which transforms these low-level information to higher-level information (e.g., extracts shapes for object recognition).
- ***Secondly***, processing which is connected with a person's concepts and expectations (knowledge) and selective mechanisms (attention) that influence perception.

- Perception depends on complex functions of the nervous system, but subjectively seems mostly effortless because this processing happens outside conscious awareness.

- What makes human perception so interesting is that we do not solely respond to the stimuli in our environment.

Perception

- We go beyond the information that is present in our environment, pay selective attention to some aspects of the environment, and ignore other elements that may be immediately apparent to other people.

- Our perception of the environment is not entirely rational.

- For example, have you ever noticed that while glancing at a newspaper or a news Web site, information that is interesting or important to you jumps out of the page and ***catches your eye***?

Visual Perception

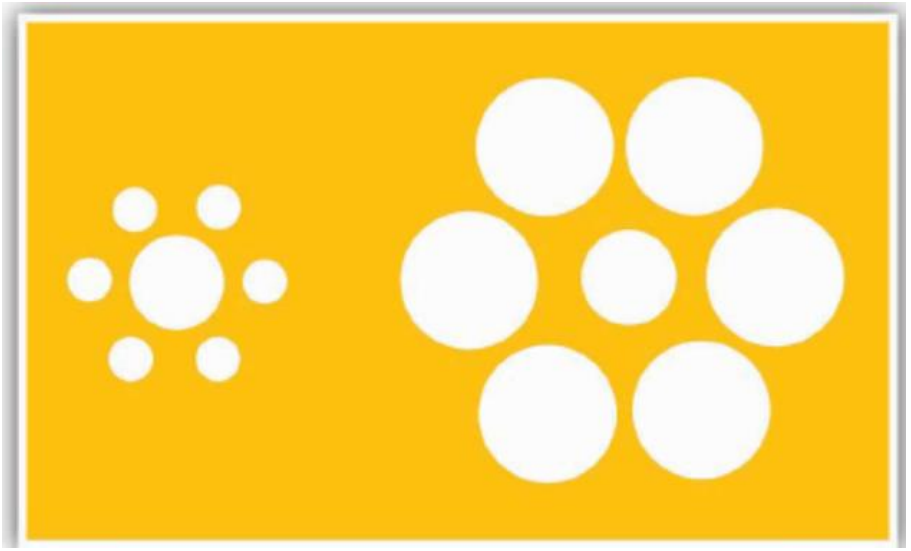
Our ***visual perception*** goes beyond the physical information available to us.

- White triangle you see in the middle is not really there
- We extrapolate from the information available to us and see it there.



Visual Perception

Which of the middle circles is bigger?

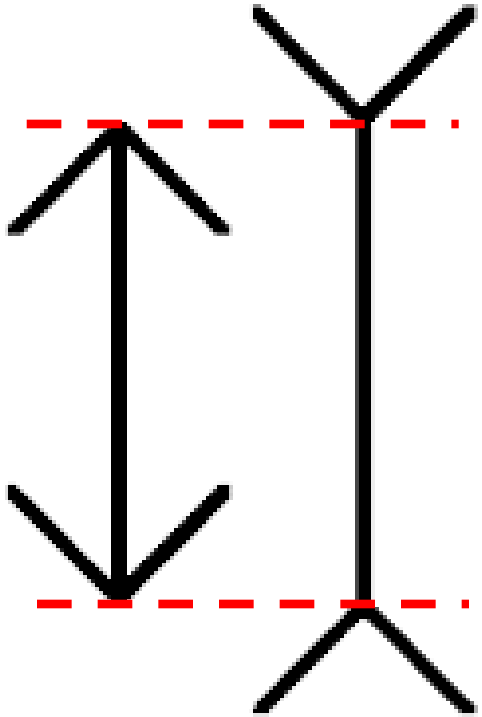


Contrast between the focal object and the objects surrounding it may make an object bigger or smaller to our eye.

Our visual perception is often ***biased*** because we do not perceive objects in isolation.

Visual Perception

Which of the line is bigger?



Perception

How do these tendencies (perceptions) influence behavior in organizations?

- You may have realized that the fact that our visual perception is faulty may make witness testimony ***faulty*** and ***biased***.

- How do we know whether the employee you judge to be hardworking, fast, and neat is really like that?

Perception

- Is it really true, or are we comparing this person to other people in the immediate environment?
- Or let's say that you do not like one of your peers and you think that this person is constantly surfing the Web during work hours. ***Are you sure?***

- Have you really seen this person surf unrelated Web sites, or is it possible that the person was surfing the Web for work-related purposes?

Our biased visual perception may lead to the wrong inferences about the people around us.

Self-Perception

- Human beings are prone to errors and biases when perceiving themselves. Moreover, the type of bias people have depends on their personality.
- Many people suffer from ***self-enhancement bias***.
- This is the tendency to overestimate our performance and capabilities and see ourselves in a more positive light than others see us.
- People who have a narcissistic personality are particularly subject to this bias, but many others are still prone to overestimating their abilities.

Social Perception

- How we perceive other people in our environment is also shaped by our values, emotions, feelings, and personality.
- Moreover, how we perceive others will shape our behavior, which in turn will shape the behavior of the person we are interacting with.

- One of the factors biasing our perception is stereotypes. Stereotypes are generalizations based on group characteristics.
- For example, believing that women are more cooperative than men, or men are more assertive than women, is a stereotype. Stereotypes may be positive, negative, or neutral.

Social Perception

- Human beings have a natural tendency to categorize the information around them to make sense of their environment.
- What makes stereotypes potentially discriminatory and a perceptual bias is the tendency to generalize from a group to a particular individual.
- If the belief that men are more assertive than women leads to choosing a man over an equally (or potentially more) qualified female candidate for a position, the decision will be biased, potentially illegal, and unfair.

OB Toolbox: How Can I Make a Great First Impression in the Job Interview?



- ***Your first opportunity to make a great impression starts even before the interview, the moment you send your résumé***.
  - Be sure that you send your résumé to the correct people, and spell the name of the contact person correctly!
  - Make sure that your résumé looks professional and is free from typos and grammar problems.
  - Have someone else read it before you hit the send button or mail it.

- ***Be prepared for the interview.*** Many interviews have some standard questions such as "tell me about yourself" or "why do you want to work here?"
- Be ready to answer these questions.
  - Prepare answers highlighting your skills and accomplishments, and practice your message.
  - Better yet, practice an interview with a friend. Practicing your answers will prevent you from regretting your answers or finding a better answer after the interview is over!

OB Toolbox: How Can I Make a Great First Impression in the Job Interview?



- ***Research the company.*** If you know a lot about the company and the job in question, you will come out as someone who is really interested in the job.
  - If you ask basic questions such as "what does this company do?" you will not be taken as a serious candidate.
  - Visit the company's Web site as well as others, and learn as much about the company and the job as you can.

- ***When you are invited for an office interview, be sure to dress properly.*** Like it or not, the manner you dress is a big part of the impression you make.
  - Dress properly for the job and company in question. In many jobs, wearing professional clothes, such as a suit, is expected. In some information technology jobs, it may be more proper to wear clean and neat business casual clothes (such as khakis and a pressed shirt) as opposed to dressing formally.
  - Do some investigation about what is suitable. Whatever the norm is, make sure that your clothes fit well and are clean and neat.

OB Toolbox: How Can I Make a Great First Impression in the Job Interview?



- ***Be on time to the interview.*** Being late will show that you either don't care about the interview or you are not very reliable.
  - While waiting for the interview, don't forget that your interview has already started.
  - As soon as you enter the company's parking lot, every person you see on the way or talk to may be a potential influence over the decision maker.
  - Act professionally and treat everyone nicely.

- ***During the interview, be polite***. Use correct grammar, show eagerness and enthusiasm, and watch your body language.
  - From your handshake to your posture, your body is communicating whether you are the right person for the job!

That is all